

Ten Questions Every Research Team Should Ask Before Engaging Consumers

Ask these before recruitment, not after. Each one is a decision in disguise.

Consumer engagement in research succeeds or fails on the questions asked early. These are the ten worth settling before you approach a single person.

1 What decision will their input actually shape?

If you cannot answer this, you are not yet ready to ask.

2 Are we inviting them early enough to matter?

Once the protocol is fixed, you are asking for approval, not partnership.

3 Whose experience do we most need, and who is hardest to reach?

The reachable and the relevant are rarely the same people.

4 Who might we be leaving out, and why?

Absence shapes findings as much as presence does.

5 How will we pay for their time and expertise?

Settle the rate before you invite, not after.

6 What would make taking part genuinely accessible?

Time, format, travel, and support are all part of the invitation.

7 What are we asking people to do, in plain terms?

If you cannot explain the role simply, it is not yet clear.

8 How will what people tell us change what we do?

Name the mechanism, or the input has nowhere to go.

9 How and when will we report back?

People who never hear the outcome do not return.

10 How will this outlive the project?

Partnership built once and then lost is a cost, not an asset.
